



A FREE RESOURCE FROM WHOLECLAIM

THE FIRST 72 HOURS

A Homeowner's Guide to Documenting Property Damage Before Details
Get Lost

When property damage happens, the first few hours can feel overwhelming.

Water damage. Storm damage. Fire. Theft. Unexpected repairs.

In the middle of the stress, important details can disappear quickly:

- When the damage was discovered
- What areas were affected
- What items were damaged
- What repairs were performed
- What expenses occurred
- What conversations happened

Good documentation helps you keep a clear record of what happened.

This guide helps you organize the information you may need after property damage occurs.

Table of Contents

- 01 The First Priority: Preserve the Scene and Record Details
- 02 Create Your Loss Timeline
- 03 Capture Photos and Videos Correctly
- 04 Document Damaged Property
- 05 Save Repair and Expense Records
- 06 Organize Communication Records
- 07 Create a Central Documentation System
- 08 The First 72 Hours Checklist

01

The First Priority: Preserve the Scene and Record Details

After discovering damage, your first step is safety.

Before documenting anything:

- Address immediate safety concerns
- Prevent additional damage when reasonable
- Avoid unnecessary changes to damaged areas until you have recorded what happened

Start creating a record as soon as possible.

Write down:

- Date damage was discovered
- Approximate time discovered
- Location of damage
- What you observed
- Actions already taken

Small details become harder to remember as time passes.

02

Create Your Loss Timeline

A timeline helps organize events in the order they happened.

Start with the first known event.

Example

DATE	June 15
EVENT	Water noticed in basement
OBSERVATION	Flooring and drywall showed visible damage
ACTION TAKEN	Shut off water supply and contacted plumber

Continue adding:

- Inspections
- Repairs
- Contractor visits
- Purchases
- Important communications

Keep the timeline factual.

Record what happened, when it happened, and what actions were taken.

03

Capture Photos and Videos Correctly

Photos and videos provide a visual record of damage.

Helpful documentation practices:

Take wide photos first

Show:

- The room
- The location
- Surrounding areas

Then take closer photos showing:

- Specific damage
- Materials affected
- Visible conditions

Include context

A close-up photo may show damage, but a wider photo helps show where the damage occurred.

Keep original files

Avoid editing or compressing photos when possible.

Keep:

- Original photos
- Original videos
- Dates and file information

04

Document Damaged Property

Create a list of affected items.

Include:

- Item description
- Location
- Approximate age
- Purchase information if available
- Photos if available

Example

ITEM	Living room sofa
LOCATION	Main floor
APPROXIMATE AGE	3 years
DOCUMENTATION	Purchase receipt saved

Do not rely only on memory.

A written inventory helps preserve details.

05

Save Repair and Expense Records

Keep records related to the damage.

Examples:

- Contractor estimates
- Invoices
- Receipts
- Emergency service records
- Materials purchased
- Inspection reports

For each document, record:

- Date
- Company/person involved
- Description
- Amount paid (if applicable)

A complete record makes it easier to understand the history of the event.

06

Organize Communication Records

Important information can be spread across:

- Emails
- Text messages
- Phone calls
- Written notices

Create a communication log.

Example

DATE	June 18
CONTACT	Plumbing company
PURPOSE	Emergency repair discussion
NOTES	Technician scheduled visit

Keeping communication organized prevents important details from getting lost.

07

Create a Central Documentation System

Many homeowners store information in different places:

- Phone photos
- Email attachments
- Paper receipts
- Text messages
- Computer folders

A central system helps keep everything together.

Your documentation system should include:

- ✓ Timeline
- ✓ Photos and videos
- ✓ Property inventory
- ✓ Receipts
- ✓ Repair records
- ✓ Communication records

The goal is simple:

Create one organized record of what happened.

08

The First 72 Hours Checklist

IMMEDIATE ACTIONS

- ☐ Confirm safety concerns are addressed
- ☐ Record the date and time damage was discovered
- ☐ Take photos and videos
- ☐ Write down initial observations
- ☐ Document temporary actions taken

DOCUMENTATION

- ☐ Create a timeline
- ☐ List damaged areas
- ☐ Record damaged items
- ☐ Save receipts and invoices
- ☐ Save contractor information

ORGANIZATION

- ☐ Store photos in one location
- ☐ Keep documents together
- ☐ Track important communications
- ☐ Update records as new information becomes available

FINAL THOUGHTS

Property damage can create confusion quickly.

A clear record helps you remember important details and keep your information organized.

The best time to create documentation is before details are forgotten.

WholeClaim helps homeowners organize their claim documentation in one place

with tools designed to keep records, evidence, and important information together.

[Learn more about organizing your documentation with WholeClaim](#)



getwholeclaim.com

© 2026 Benjamin Hammonds. All rights reserved.

WholeClaim is a self-help documentation tool, not legal or insurance advice.